

Interpretive phenomenological analysis

Definition

IPA is a quantitative form of psychology research. IPA has an idiographic focus, which means that instead of producing generalization findings, it aims to offer insights into how a given person, in a given context, make sense of a given situation.

Phenomenology guides our future. If we ought to understand someone we study phenomenology.

ABOUT IPA

Interpretative phenomenology analysis (IPA) is a relatively recent qualitative approach developed specifically with psychology. It is now being used widely by researchers in health clinical and social psychology particularly in UK.

Components of IPA

1. Ideography method
2. Phenomenology method
3. Hermeneutic method

Ideography method

Ideographic method is an approach in psychology that focuses on the individual case or person rather than trying to generalize findings to large population. IPA involves selecting a small group of people who have shared particular experience.

Phenomenology method

This method focuses on understanding how individuals experience the world and how we go about making sense of those experiences. IPA focuses on the lived experiences of individuals.

Hermeneutic method

It is a verbal analysis method. Hermeneutic is a theory and practice of interpreting texts, considering context, language, culture and the interpreters own perspective. It guides IPA researchers to interpret and analyze qualitative data in a rigorous way. It leads to deeper understanding of human experiences and their meanings.

Sampling in IPA

The main concern in IPA is give full appreciation to each participants account (case). For this reason, samples in IPA studies are usually small, which enables a detailed and very time consuming case-by-case analysis. Size is not predetermined.

Sample size depends upon four points

1. How much we analyze in depth information.
2. The richness of individual cases.
3. How the researcher wants to compare contrast single cases.

The last category includes time constraints or access to participants.

Data collection

In IPA researchers gather qualitative data from research participants using following techniques.

1. Interviews
2. Diaries
3. Focus Group

Typically, these are approached from a position of flexible and open-ended inquiry, and the interviewer adopts a stance which is curious and facilitative (rather than say, challenging and interrogative).

Data analysis

Data collection does no set out to test hypothesis, and this stance is maintained in data analysis.

IPA hermeneutic stance is one of inquiry and meaning making. Analysis in IPA is said to be **bottom up**. This means that the researcher generates codes from the data, rather than using a pre-existing theory to identify codes that might be applied to the data.

After transcribing the data, the researcher works closely and intensively with the text, annotating is closely **coding** for insights into the participants experience and perspective on their world.

As the analysis develops, the researcher catalogues the emerging codes and subsequently begins to look for patterns in the codes. These patterns are called **Themes**.

Themes are recurring patterns of meaning (ideas, thoughts, feelings) throughout the text.

For example

In a study of experiences of young people learning to drive, we might find themes like “Driving as a rite passage” where one key psychosocial understanding of the meaning of learning to drive, is that it makes a cultural threshold between adolescence and adulthood.

The analysis

In IPA a good analysis is one which balances phenomenological description with insightful interpretation, and which anchors these interpretations in the participants account. It is also likely to maintain an idiographic focus and to keep a close focus on meaning.

Pros and Cons of IPA

Pros

- IPA generates rich and detailed data that provides a deep understanding of individual's experience.
- IPA is a flexible methodology that can adapted to a range of fields, research questions and contexts.
- The idiographic approach of IPA allows for a deep understanding of the unique experiences of each participant.

Cons

- IPA is a subjective methodology, which means that interpretations of researcher may be influenced by their own bases and preconceptions.
- Conducting IPA research can be time-consuming.
- IPA often involves working with small sample sizes. Smaller sample size can limit the generalizability of the findings.
- IPA does not have a widely accepted approach to data analysis.

CONCLUSION

IPA is a research process of examining how individuals make sense of an experience. Rooted in phenomenology, it focuses on the meanings attached to those subjective experiences.

While IPA generates rich and detailed data, it also has some limitations. This includes its subjectivity, time-consuming nature, small sample sizes and lack of standardization.

Despite its limitations, IPA offers a systematic way to understand the subjective experiences of individuals, particularly in fields such as psychology, sociology and health care,

